# School Phone Bans Cut Screen Time 15% — and Changed Nothing

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My kids are not school age yet, so school phone bans are not my problem. Or so I thought, until I read the numbers this week and realized they might explain a lot about why my own screen time rules keep working and then quietly not working.

The data comes from Findmykids, which tracked anonymized phone use among US kids aged 9 to 18 over the past year. In-school phone time fell about 15% as bans rolled out. Sounds like a win. Except total screen time did not drop at all. The minutes did not vanish — they moved. Time shifted off games and onto social media.

So the bans did exactly what bans do: they removed the phone from one specific place, during one specific set of hours. And the kids, being kids, simply rerouted. The habit was never about the school building. The school building was just where the habit happened to live for seven hours a day.

I have been thinking about this all week because it is the same thing that happens in my house, just smaller. I have written before about our screen time rules, and I stand by them. But I have noticed something: every rule I have made that was about *where* the screen is allowed has held, and every rule that was about *how much* the screen is wanted has quietly eroded. No screens at the table — still standing, a year later. No screens in the hour before bed — still standing. “Only thirty minutes of shows” — that one died within a month, because thirty minutes is a number I made up and my daughter knows it is a number I made up.

The phone ban data is the school-sized version of the same lesson. Structure beats willpower. The schools did not convince a single teenager to want their phone less. They just changed the room. And it worked, for the room. But the wanting went somewhere else, because nobody addressed the wanting.

What does that mean for a house with small kids and a parent who is tired? I think it means I should stop trying to make my kids want screens less — a project that, if we are honest, I have never succeeded at with myself either — and spend that energy on the structure instead. The phone charges in the kitchen, not the bedroom. The TV goes off when the episode ends, not when some timer beeps mid-scene. The default is set once, calmly, and then nobody has to be the villain enforcing it every day.

There is a second thing the data made me notice. The banned-school kids did not just use phones less at school — they used them differently afterward, more social media, fewer games. The restriction did not reduce the appetite; it redirected it. I see this with my daughter and the "one episode" rule. She accepts the end of the episode fine. Then she asks for my phone. The screen time did not end; it changed platforms, from the TV to the thing in my pocket. I had not been counting that as screen time. I am counting it now.

I am not against the school bans. Fifteen percent less distraction in class is real, and teachers deserve it. I just think we should be honest about what bans are: a change of venue, not a change of heart. If I want less total screen time in my house — theirs and mine — the data is pretty clear that moving the phone to a different room will not do it. I have to change the room *and* give the wanting somewhere else to go. For my kids, that somewhere is the boring stuff: the park, the crayons, the dad who put his own phone in the kitchen and is actually paying attention. That last one is the hardest rule in the house. It is also the only one that ever reduced anybody's screen time without a fight.